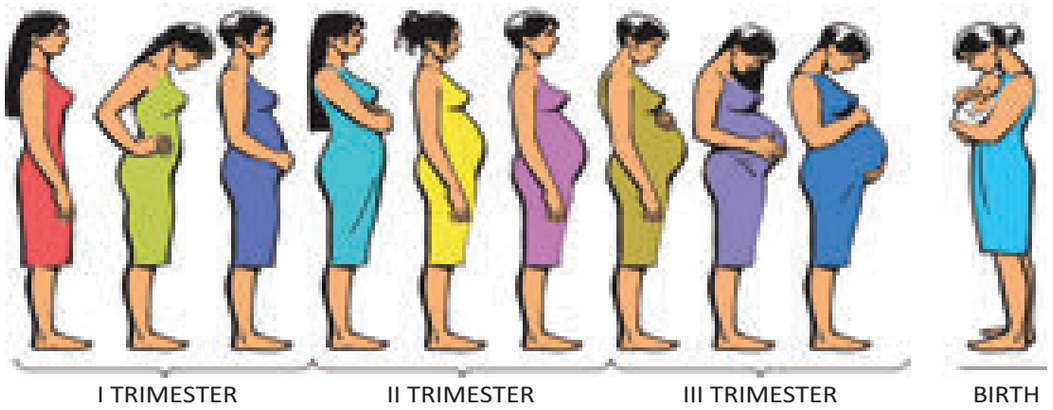


Fig 2.1 Stages of pregnancy

- There is a decreased ability to taste saltiness. This may in fact, be a physiologic mechanism for increasing salt intake.
- The ability to excrete water is lowered and oedema in the legs and ankle is common and normal.
- Gastrointestinal motility diminishes, to allow for increased absorption of nutrients. This often results in constipation.
- A relaxed lower oesophageal sphincter can cause regurgitation and heart burns.
- Increased progesterone level relaxes the uterine muscle to allow expansion with foetal growth.
- High oestrogen levels during pregnancy promote a gynaecoid type of fat distribution.

2.1 b. Role of Placenta

The placenta is the principal site of production for several hormones responsible for regulation of foetal growth and development of maternal support tissues. It is also involved for exchange of nutrients, oxygen and waste products.

2.1.1 Weight gain during pregnancy

A healthy women gains an average weight about 11-13 kg during pregnancy. About 900 to 1800g is an average gain during the first trimester. Thereafter 450 gram/ week during the remaining of the pregnancy is usual.

The overweight women (20 % or more above the ideal weight for height and age) entering pregnancy have increased risk of complications like hypertension, diabetics, etc. Even in this group it is not advisable to restrict weight gain by limiting calories from food intake. Hence obese women should receive atleast 30 kcal/ kg body weight and are advised to reduce weight by exercise rather than diet restriction. While low weight gain in pregnancy is associated with a higher incidence of pre - maturity and low birth weight babies.

"Sharp sudden increase in weight after the 12th week of pregnancy which may indicate excessive, abnormal water retention, should be watched. Weight reduction should never be undertaken during pregnancy. Excessive weight gain places an extra strain on the organs and increase the incidence of toxaemia."



The uterus enlarges up to 500 times its normal size? It can go from a couple of ounces to 1-2 pounds in weight. Once after delivery it gradually goes back to its original size.

Tables 2.1 and 2.2 give the components of weight gain during pregnancy and recommended weight gain based on body mass index.

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